Himaayah Schools
MADRASAH

FREE GUIDE

وَرَتِّلِ الْقُرْآنَ تَرْتِيلًا

"And recite the Qur'an with measured recitation." (al-Muzzammil 73:4)

Tajwīd Basics

The rules of reciting the Qur'an, in the readings of Ḥafṣ ʿan ʿĀṣim and Warsh ʿan Nāfiʿ, side by side.

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَٰنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Before you begin

Tajwīd means making something excellent. In the recitation of the Qur'an, it means giving every letter its right: pronouncing it from its proper place (makhraj) with its proper qualities (ṣifāt), and applying the rules that come from how the Prophet ﷺ recited, as he received it from Jibrīl. Allah says: "And recite the Qur'an with measured recitation" (al-Muzzammil 73:4). It is reported that ʿAlī explained tartīl as "giving the letters their proper pronunciation and knowing where to stop."

Imām Ibn al-Jazarī, the great master of the readings, wrote in his famous poem:

> وَالْأَخْذُ بِالتَّجْوِيدِ حَتْمٌ لَازِمُ ۞ مَنْ لَمْ يُجَوِّدِ الْقُرْآنَ آثِمُ
>
> **"Taking hold of tajwīd is a binding necessity; whoever does not recite the Qur'an with tajwīd is sinful."**
>
> Ibn al-Jazarī, al-Muqaddimah al-Jazariyyah. The scholars explain: avoiding clear mistakes (al-laḥn al-jaliyy) is obligatory on every reciter; learning the detailed rules is a communal obligation.

Kind of mistake	Example	Ruling
Clear mistake (laḥn jaliyy)	Changing a letter or a vowel, which can change the meaning: reading أَنْعَمْتُ (I favoured) instead of أَنْعَمْتَ (You favoured)	Forbidden; must be corrected
Hidden mistake (laḥn khafiyy)	Missing a ghunnah, shortening a madd, making a heavy letter light	Disliked; the reciter should work to remove it

Ḥafṣ and Warsh

The Qur'an was revealed in more than one authentic way of reading (the aḥruf), all from Allah. The scholars preserved ten readings (qirāʾāt), each transmitted by two famous narrators (rāwīs). This guide compares the two most widespread:

Ḥafṣ ʿan ʿĀṣim

The reading of ʿ**Āṣim** of Kūfah, as narrated by his student **Ḥafṣ ibn Sulaymān**. It is the reading of most of the Muslim world today, and of most printed muṣḥafs, including those printed in Madinah.

Warsh ʿan Nāfiʿ

The reading of **Nāfi**ʿ, the Imām of Madinah and teacher of Imām Mālik, as narrated by **Warsh**, by the way (ṭarīq) of al-Azraq. It is the reading of North and West Africa, including much of Nigeria, and is printed in its own muṣḥafs.

How to use this guide

Tajwīd is learned **by listening and reciting to a teacher**, not from a book alone. Use this guide to understand the rules, then recite to a qualified teacher who will correct you.

Each rule is explained for both readings where they agree. Where they differ, a box shows **Ḥafṣ** in blue and **Warsh** in brown. Follow the reading of your muṣḥaf and your teacher; do not mix readings within one recitation.

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Part 1 The makhārij: where the letters come from

Each Arabic letter has its own point of articulation (makhraj). The scholars of tajwīd, following al-Khalīl and Ibn al-Jazarī, count **seventeen** makhārij in **five** regions. To find a letter's makhraj, put a sukūn on it and a hamzah with a vowel before it: أَبْ، أَتْ، أَثْ. Where the sound stops is its makhraj.

The five regions of the makhārij where the letters are pronounced



Makhraj	Letters	How
Deepest part of the throat	ء ه	The hamzah is a clear catch; the hā' is breathy, never dropped
Middle of the throat	ع ح	'Ayn is voiced from a tightened throat; ḥā' is a sharp, breathy h
Nearest part of the throat	غ خ	Like gargling: ghayn voiced, khā' voiceless
Back of the tongue	ق ك	Qāf further back, against the soft palate; kāf a little forward
Middle of the tongue	ج ش ي	Middle of the tongue against the hard palate
Side of the tongue	ض	One or both sides of the tongue against the upper molars: the letter unique to Arabic
Edge and tip of the tongue	ل ن ر	Lām along the front edges; nūn at the tip; rā' just behind the tip
Tip of the tongue and upper teeth	ط د ت	Tip against the roots of the upper front teeth
Tip of the tongue and edge of the teeth	ظ ذ ث	Tip of the tongue touches the edges of the upper front teeth; the tongue shows slightly
Tip of the tongue near the lower teeth	ص ز س	The whistling letters, with a narrow passage for air
The lips	ف ب م و	Fā': lower lip and upper teeth. Bā', mīm: lips closed. Wāw: lips rounded, not closed

Part 2 The ṣifāt: qualities of the letters

Heavy and light letters

Seven letters are always **heavy** (mufakhkham): the tongue rises to the roof of the mouth, giving a full, deep sound. They are gathered in the phrase خُصَّ ضَغْطٍ قِظْ: خ ص ض غ ط ق ظ. All other letters are **light** (muraqqaq), except alif, lām and rāʾ, which can be either.

Letter group	Letters	Rule
Always heavy	خ ص ض غ ط ق ظ	Heavy, most of all with fatḥah, then ḍammah, and least with kasrah
Alif	ا	Follows the letter before it: heavy after a heavy letter (قَالَ), light after a light one (كَانَ)
Lām of the name Allah	اللَّه	Heavy after fatḥah or ḍammah (قَالَ ٱللَّهُ، رَسُولُ ٱللَّهِ); light after kasrah (بِسْمِ ٱللَّهِ)

The rāʾ

In both readings, rāʾ is **heavy** when it has fatḥah or ḍammah (رَبِّ، رُزِقُوا), and **light** when it has kasrah (رِجَالٌ). A rāʾ with sukūn follows the vowel before it: light after kasrah (فِرْعَوْنَ), heavy after fatḥah or ḍammah (ٱلْأَرْضِ، ٱلْقُرْءَانُ). But Warsh adds a well-known rule:

Ḥafṣ ʿan ʿĀṣim

Rāʾ with fatḥah or ḍammah is **always heavy**.

خَبِيرًا · بَصِيرًا · ٱلْخَيْرَاتِ

All read with a heavy rāʾ.

Warsh ʿan Nāfiʿ

Rāʾ with fatḥah or ḍammah is made **light** when it comes after a **kasrah** or a **sākin yā**ʾ in the same word (with some exceptions).

خَبِيرًا · بَصِيرًا · ٱلْخَيْرَاتِ

All read with a light rāʾ in Warsh.

The lām in Warsh

Ḥafṣ ʿan ʿĀṣim

The lām is always light, except in the name Allah.

ٱلصَّلَوٰةَ · ظَلَمُوا · ٱلطَّلَاقُ

Warsh ʿan Nāfiʿ

A lām with **fatḥah** is made **heavy** (taghlīẓ) when it comes after **ṣād, ṭāʾ or ẓāʾ** that have fatḥah or sukūn.

ٱلصَّلَوٰةَ · ظَلَمُوا · ٱلطَّلَاقُ

All read with a heavy lām in Warsh.

Qalqalah: the echo

Five letters, gathered in (ق ط ب ج د) قُطْبُ جَدٍّ, are pronounced with a slight **echo** or bounce when they have sukūn, so the sound is not swallowed. The echo is lighter in the middle of a word and stronger when you stop on the letter.

Where	Example	Note
Middle of a word	يَقْطَعُونَ · أَبْتَرُ	Light echo
Stopping on it	ٱلْفَلَقِ · أَحَدْ	Stronger echo, especially with shaddah: ٱلْحَقُّ

Part 3 Nūn sākinah and tanwīn

A **nūn sākinah** (نْ) and **tanwīn** (ـً ـٍ ـٌ, which is a nūn sound) follow one of four rules, depending on the letter after them. The two readings agree on these rules.

Rule	Example	Letters and how
1. Iẓhār: clear	مَنْ ءَامَنَ · عَذَابٌ أَلِيمٌ	Before the six throat letters ء ه ع ح غ خ: pronounce the nūn clearly, without ghunnah
2. Idghām with ghunnah	مَن يَقُولُ · خَيْرًا يَرَهُۥ	Before ي ن م و: merge the nūn into the next letter, with a ghunnah of two counts
3. Idghām without ghunnah	مِن رَّبِّهِمْ · هُدًى لِّلْمُتَّقِينَ	Before ر ل: merge completely, with no ghunnah
4. Iqlāb: changing	مِنۢ بَعْدِ · سَمِيعٌۢ بَصِيرٌ	Before ب: change the nūn to a hidden mīm, with ghunnah, lips lightly closed
5. Ikhfāʾ: hiding	مِن قَبْلِ · أَنتُمْ · رِيحًا صَرْصَرًا	Before the other fifteen letters: hide the nūn, keeping a ghunnah, with the tongue preparing for the next letter

The letters of idghām are gathered in the word يَرْمَلُونَ: ي ر م ل و ن. Idghām happens only between two words. Within one word, the nūn is pronounced clearly, as in ٱلدُّنْيَا، بُنْيَانٌ، صِنْوَانٌ، قِنْوَانٌ.

Part 4 Mīm sākinah and ghunnah

Rule	Example	How
Ikhfāʾ shafawī	تَرْمِيهِم بِحِجَارَةٍ	Before ب: hide the mīm with ghunnah, lips lightly closed
Idghām shafawī	لَهُم مَّا يَشَاءُونَ	Before م: merge into one mīm with shaddah and ghunnah
Iẓhār shafawī	لَكُمْ دِينُكُمْ · عَلَيْهِمْ وَلَا	Before all other letters: pronounce the mīm clearly, especially before و and ف

Ghunnah is the nasal sound from the nose. Every **nūn and mīm with shaddah** (إِنَّ، ثُمَّ) carries a full ghunnah of **two counts** in both readings.

Ṣilah of mīm al-jamʿ: an important difference

Ḥafṣ ʿan ʿĀṣim

The mīm of the plural (هُمْ، كُمْ) is always read with **sukūn**.

عَلَيْهِمْ ءَأَنذَرْتَهُمْ أَمْ لَمْ تُنذِرْهُمْ

ʿalayhim aʾandhartahum am lam tundhirhum

Warsh ʿan Nāfiʿ

When the mīm of the plural comes before a **hamzah**, it is joined with a ḍammah and a wāw (ṣilah) and lengthened six counts.

عَلَيْهِمُوٓ ءَآنذَرْتَهُمُوٓ أَمْ لَمْ تُنذِرْهُمْ

ʿalayhimū ʾāndhartahumū am lam tundhirhum

Part 5 The madd: lengthening

Madd is lengthening the sound of a madd letter: alif after fatḥah, wāw sākinah after ḍammah, yāʾ sākinah after kasrah. A **count** (ḥarakah) is roughly the time it takes to fold or unfold one finger at a steady pace. This is where Ḥafṣ and Warsh differ most.

Kind of madd	Example	Ḥafṣ	Warsh
Natural (ṭabīʿī): no hamzah or sukūn after it	قَالَ · يَقُولُ · قِيلَ	2	2
Connected (muttaṣil): hamzah after it in the same word	جَآءَ · ٱلسَّمَآءِ · سُوٓءَ	4 or 5	6
Separated (munfaṣil): hamzah at the start of the next word	بِمَآ أُنزِلَ · قُوٓا أَنفُسَكُمْ	4 or 5	6
Necessary (lāzim): a permanent sukūn after it	ٱلضَّآلِّينَ · الٓمٓ	6	6
For stopping (ʿāriḍ lis-sukūn): sukūn only because you stop	ٱلْعَٰلَمِينَ · نَسْتَعِينُ	2, 4 or 6	2, 4 or 6
Badal: hamzah before the madd letter	ءَامَنُوا · إِيمَٰنًا · أُوتُوا	2	2, 4 or 6
Līn: wāw or yāʾ sākinah after fatḥah, then hamzah in the same word	شَيْءٍ · سَوْءَةً	2 (when not stopping)	4 or 6
Līn when stopping	خَوْفٍ · ٱلْبَيْتِ	2, 4 or 6	2, 4 or 6

Whichever length you choose for a kind of madd, keep it **the same throughout** your recitation. In Ḥafṣ, the muttaṣil and munfaṣil are read 4 or 5 counts by the way of the Shāṭibiyyah, which is what most teachers teach; other authentic ways allow other lengths. In Warsh by the way of al-Azraq, both are read 6 counts.

The pronoun hāʾ (hāʾ al-kināyah)

The hāʾ meaning "him/his" (هُۥ، هِۦ) is lengthened when it comes between two vowelled letters: إِنَّهُۥ كَانَ, بِهِۦ عِلْمٌ. If the next word begins with a hamzah, Ḥafṣ lengthens it 4 or 5 counts and Warsh 6 counts: عِندَهُۥٓ إِلَّا. A famous exception in Ḥafṣ is مُهَانًا فِيهِۦ (al-Furqān 25:69), which he lengthens, though the hāʾ follows a sākin letter.

Part 6 Hamzah and other features of Warsh

The reading of Warsh treats the hamzah in special ways. A reciter of Ḥafṣ will hear these differences when listening to Warsh, and should know them so as not to think they are mistakes.

Ḥafṣ ʿan ʿĀṣim

Hamzah sākinah is pronounced as a hamzah.

يُؤْمِنُونَ · يَأْكُلُونَ · ٱلْمُؤْمِنُونَ

Warsh ʿan Nāfiʿ

Ibdāl: a hamzah sākinah that is the first root letter of the word is changed into a madd letter.

يُومِنُونَ · يَاكُلُونَ · ٱلْمُومِنُونَ

Ḥafṣ ʿan ʿĀṣim

A sākin letter followed by a hamzah at the start of the next word is pronounced with its sukūn.

قَدْ أَفْلَحَ · مَنْ ءَامَنَ · ٱلْأَرْضُ

Warsh ʿan Nāfiʿ

Naql: the vowel of the hamzah is moved to the sākin letter before it, and the hamzah is dropped.

قَدَ اَفْلَحَ · مَنَ اٰمَنَ · اَلَارْضُ

Ḥafṣ ʿan ʿĀṣim

Two hamzahs together in one word are both pronounced clearly.

ءَأَنذَرْتَهُمْ

Warsh ʿan Nāfiʿ

Tashīl: the second hamzah is softened between a hamzah and an alif; Warsh also has the option of changing it to a long alif (ibdāl).

ءَآنذَرْتَهُمْ

Ḥafṣ ʿan ʿĀṣim

Imālah (tilting the alif towards yāʾ) is read in only one word in the Qur'an: مَجْرٖىٰهَا (Hūd 11:41).

Other words ending in alif maqṣūrah are read with a plain fatḥah.

Warsh ʿan Nāfiʿ

Taqlīl (a slight tilt, between fatḥah and imālah) in many words ending in alif maqṣūrah, and in the rhyming endings of sūrahs such as Ṭā Hā and ash-Shams.

مُوسَىٰ · ٱلْهُدَىٰ · ضُحَىٰهَا

Other differences you will notice

Feature	Ḥafṣ	Warsh
Between two sūrahs	Basmalah between every two sūrahs, except before at-Tawbah	Three options: basmalah, a short pause (sakt), or joining the sūrahs
Brief pauses (sakt)	A short pause without breath in four places, e.g. عِوَجَاۜ قَيِّمًا (al-Kahf 18:1–2)	No sakt in these places
Some words read differently	مَٰلِكِ يَوْمِ ٱلدِّينِ (al-Fātiḥah 1:4)	مَلِكِ يَوْمِ ٱلدِّينِ, both authentic readings
Stop signs	The signs of the Madinah muṣḥaf (م، لا، ج، صلى، قلى ∴)	Warsh muṣḥafs in West Africa mark stops with a single sign (ṣah), following al-Habṭī

Part 7 Stopping and starting (al-waqf wal-ibtidāʾ)

Knowing where to stop is half of tartīl. Stopping in the wrong place can change the meaning: stopping after لَا تَقْرَبُوا ٱلصَّلَوٰةَ ("Do not approach the prayer") without completing وَأَنتُمْ سُكَٰرَىٰ ("while you are intoxicated") gives a false meaning.

How to stop on a word

- Stop on the last letter with **sukūn**: نَسْتَعِينْ ,ٱلْعَٰلَمِينْ.
- A **tāʾ marbūṭah** (ة) becomes a **hāʾ** when you stop: رَحْمَةْ → رَحْمَهْ.
- **Tanwīn with fatḥah** becomes a long **alif**: عَلِيمًا → عَلِيمَا. Other tanwīn is dropped: عَلِيمٌ → عَلِيمْ.
- When starting again, start from a place that gives a complete, correct meaning, not from the middle of a phrase.

The stop signs of the Madinah muṣḥaf (Ḥafṣ)

Sign	Meaning
مـ	Necessary stop: continuing would change the meaning
لا	Do not stop here (unless at the end of a verse)
ج	Stopping and continuing are equal
صلى	Continuing is better, stopping is allowed
قلى	Stopping is better, continuing is allowed
∴ ∴	Stop at one of the two places, not both

Stopping at the end of every verse is a sunnah: Umm Salamah described the Prophet ﷺ reciting al-Fātiḥah verse by verse, stopping at each (Abū Dāwūd 4001, at-Tirmidhī 2927).

Practice A daily practice checklist

Check	Ask yourself
Makhārij	Are ح and ع, ه and ق, ء and ص, ك and ز ظ ذ, س clearly different?
Heavy letters	Are خ ص ض غ ط ق ظ full and deep, even with kasrah?
Light letters	Am I making light letters heavy, especially after heavy ones?
Nūn and mīm	Is every ghunnah two counts? Is ikhfāʾ hidden, not clear?
Madd	Is each kind of madd the same length every time?
Qalqalah	Do ق ط ب ج د echo when they have sukūn?
Stopping	Am I stopping at the end of verses and at places that keep the meaning?
Reading	Am I following one reading only, from my muṣḥaf and my teacher?

Test Self-test

Choose the best answer. The answers follow the questions.

1. How many makhārij are counted by Ibn al-Jazarī?

a) 5 b) 10 c) 17 d) 29

2. Which letters are always heavy?

a) خ ص ض غ ط ق ظ b) ق ط ب ج د c) ي ر م ل و ن d) ء ه ع ح غ خ

3. The letters of qalqalah are gathered in:

a) يرملون b) قطب جد c) خص ضغط قظ d) أبث

4. Nūn sākinah before ب is read with:

a) Iẓhār b) Idghām c) Iqlāb d) Ikhfāʾ

5. In مِن رَّبِّهِمْ the nūn is read with:

a) Idghām without ghunnah b) Ikhfāʾ c) Iẓhār d) Iqlāb

6. How long is the ghunnah on a nūn or mīm with shaddah?

a) 1 count b) 2 counts c) 4 counts d) 6 counts

7. In Warsh, how long are the muttaṣil and munfaṣil?

a) 2 counts b) 4 counts c) 6 counts d) 3 counts

8. In Ḥafṣ (Shāṭibiyyah), the munfaṣil is:

a) 2 counts b) 4 or 5 counts c) 6 counts d) Not lengthened

9. How does Warsh read يُؤْمِنُونَ?

a) يُؤْمِنُونَ with hamzah b) يُومِنُونَ c) يَأْمَنُونَ d) يُأْمِنُونَ

10. How does Warsh read قَدْ أَفْلَحَ?

a) With naql: قَدَ اَفْلَحَ b) With sakt c) With idghām d) Exactly like Ḥafṣ

11. In Warsh, عَلَيْهِمْ before a hamzah is read:

a) With sukūn b) With ṣilah: عَلَيْهِمُ۫ c) With kasrah d) With ghunnah

12. When you stop on رَحْمَةٌ, you say:

a) رَحْمَتْ b) رَحْمَهْ c) رَحْمَةً d) رَحْمَا

13. What does the sign لا mean in the Madinah muṣḥaf?

a) Necessary stop b) Stopping is better c) Do not stop here d) Stopping and continuing are equal

No.	Answer	No.	Answer
1	c) 17	8	b) 4 or 5 counts
2	a) خ ص ض غ ط ق ظ	9	b) يُومِنُونَ
3	b) قطب جد	10	a) Naql
4	c) Iqlāb	11	b) With ṣilah
5	a) Idghām without ghunnah	12	b) رَحْمَهْ
6	b) 2 counts	13	c) Do not stop here
7	c) 6 counts		

For further study

- **Tuḥfat al-Aṭfāl** of al-Jamzūrī, a short poem on the rules of Ḥafṣ, memorised by beginners.
- **Al-Muqaddimah al-Jazariyyah** of Ibn al-Jazarī, for the makhārij and ṣifāt.
- **Ad-Durar al-Lawāmiʿ** of Ibn Burrī, the classic poem on the reading of Nāfiʿ taught across North and West Africa.
- **Ash-Shāṭibiyyah**, for advanced students of the seven readings.
- Most important of all: recite regularly to a qualified teacher.

Learn tajwīd with a Himaayah teacher

Recite to a qualified teacher live, with correction every class, in Ḥafṣ or Warsh, five classes a week.

Find your level: himaayahschools.com/placement · **Enrol:** himaayahschools.com/enroll

Madrasah line (WhatsApp): +234 702 584 2849

وَمَا تَوْفِيقِي إِلَّا بِاللَّهِ

"And my success is only through Allah." (Hūd 11:88)

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Recite it as it was revealed.

This free guide from the Himaayah Madrasah teaches the foundations of tajwīd, comparing the reading of Ḥafṣ with the reading of Warsh followed across North and West Africa.

- Where each letter comes from: the makhārij
- Heavy and light letters, qalqalah and ghunnah
- Nūn and mīm sākinah, and the kinds of madd
- The main differences between Ḥafṣ and Warsh, with examples
- Stopping and starting, a practice checklist and a self-test

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